

The Current War Paper

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Professor Al-Hallaj

By: Michael Stacy



Thank you

The Current War was released on October 25, 2019. The movie overviewed the life of three men: Thomas Edison, George Westinghouse, and Nikola Tesla. These men all played large roles in the creation of the lightbulb. In this paper I will analyze each character, note the key differences between them, and put them into a specific category, either businessman, entrepreneur or inventor. I will also discuss intellectual property (IP) and argue that the smartest person does not always make the most money.

The first main character in *The Current War* is Thomas Edison. He was very well-known in the industrial age. Throughout the movie people would come up to him and ask for his autograph. Edison was passionate about his work; his work was his first priority. His grit and determination were major factors in his success. However, this focus on work is also the reason why he missed the passing of his wife while he was in a business meeting. Although Edison was intelligent, he was unable to put his pride aside and listen to the advice others would give. Edison, who was backed by J.P Morgan, a large banker at the time, created the lightbulb, along with a direct current (DC) system to push the power. However, the direct current could only span so far, allowing only small parts of a city to be run by one DC plant. He had the chance to partner with George Westinghouse, however, Edison was too proud and decided he did not need Westinghouse. Although Westinghouse already had dinner set for the meeting, Edison stood him up and asked his conductor to continue past Westinghouse's estate. Declining this opportunity to be partners with Westinghouse was one of Edison's biggest mistakes as Westinghouse became Edison's rival in the current business.

George Westinghouse was a very successful businessman. He saw a pain in the power grid and solved it. He was able to purchase the rights to a dynamo from another company and use it to create his own alternating current plant. Westinghouse was a smart man, however, he could not compete with Edison's intelligence. He had a chief engineer working under him designing technical instruments. The issue that the alternating current had was that it could be potentially dangerous, or at least that's what the popular Edison would claim. Westinghouse was able to get his AC plant up and running by partnering with Nikola Tesla.

Nikola Tesla was a brilliant inventor, he believed that if an invention worked in his mind, it would work, and he was right. Tesla, however, was a very weird person who lacked social skills. In the scene where Westinghouse comes in to try and partner with him, Tesla keeps getting up and checking to see if the room is slanted. He was constantly analyzing his surroundings, which is one of the things that made him so smart, however, he ended up dying alone because of his quirks.

Intellectual property is a tricky issue to work around when competing with another person or company in the same field. In the movie, when Edison first finds out that Westinghouse has started producing lightbulbs, he immediately calls out to sue him. However, Westinghouse had taken large precautions, he used the lightbulb of another inventor, and he had his own AC generator. This was an issue for Edison because he did not have grounds to sue Westinghouse. However, Edison realized that the screw system to implement the lightbulbs

was on their patent. With this information, Edison devised a plan to sue Westinghouse for use of his screw system. To avoid a lawsuit, Westinghouse revised his lightbulb to be a plug and play method to get around the patent claim. Another instance of IP is when Tesla is being fired from the job he had as an inventor, he starts packing up all of his belongings only to be stopped by the head of the company, since those inventions were all created under his employment the company owned the rights to them.

In order of highest intellect, I would list the characters as Tesla, Edison, Westinghouse. A quick google search will show that Westinghouse ended up being the richest of the three men, with a net worth of about \$50 million. Thomas Edison was second with a net worth of \$12 million. And Nikola Tesla's net worth came out to be a whopping \$1,000. All numbers are given in their time of death, not current market value after inflation. This proves that the smartest man doesn't always make the most money. Westinghouse had no IP in the game yet made out like a bandit. Edison was able to be flexible, working on his voice recording machine along with the lightbulb. Tesla couldn't sell anything and ended up not making any money off his inventions.

In the end I would say that all three men were brilliant in their own way. Westinghouse was a businessman and knew the art of the sale, he made money off other inventions just by having the money to purchase the IP. He also won the current war and the contract to light up the Chicago World Fair. Edison was an entrepreneur; he created his own business with his own inventions. Tesla was an inventor, and a brilliant one at that. However, he was unable to work into the sales end of the entrepreneurship journey and therefore did not make money from his inventions but allowed others to profit from his ideas.